Acme Corp Employee Handbook 2026

Version 3.2 — Effective 1 January 2026 — Owner: Chief People Officer

1. Introduction and Scope

This Employee Handbook (the Handbook) is issued by Acme Corp India Private Limited (Acme Corp) and is effective from 1 January 2026. It supersedes all previous handbooks, circulars, and verbal guidance on the matters covered herein.

The Handbook applies to all employees of Acme Corp on the India payroll, including full-time, part-time, and fixed-term employees. It does not apply to independent contractors, consultants engaged through vendors, or interns (who are governed by the separate Internship Policy).

This document is classified Internal. Questions about interpretation must be raised with the HR Business Partner (HRBP) assigned to your business unit, or through the HR portal at hr.acme.example.

2. Employment Classification and Probation

Every new regular employee is placed on probation for a period of six (6) months from the date of joining. Probation may be extended once, by up to three (3) additional months, with written reasons provided to the employee.

Confirmation of employment requires a probation review rating of Meets Expectations or higher, completion of all mandatory onboarding trainings, and return of all signed policy acknowledgements to HR.

Employment classifications used throughout this Handbook: Grade L1 (Associate), Grade L2 (Senior Associate), Grade L3 (Manager and above), Grade L4 (Director and above). Where a rule differs by grade, the grade recorded in the HR portal on the date the rule applies is authoritative.

3. Working Hours and Attendance

The standard work week is 45 hours, Monday to Friday. Core hours during which every office-based employee must be reachable are 10:00 to 16:00 India Standard Time; flexible band hours are 07:00 to 19:00.

Employees working more than 9 hours in a day are entitled to a 45-minute paid break in addition to the standard 30-minute lunch break.

Late attendance is recorded when an employee arrives after the end of their declared flexible band start time plus a grace period of 15 minutes. More than three (3) recorded late arrivals in a calendar month trigger a documented verbal warning from the reporting manager; six or more trigger a written warning.

Overtime compensation applies only to Grade L1 employees, at 1.5x hourly basic pay, and must be pre-approved in writing by the department head.

4. Leave Policy

The leave year runs from 1 January to 31 December. All leave must be applied for in the HR portal before it is taken, except in emergencies covered by sick leave rules below.

The following leave types and annual entitlements apply to all confirmed employees:

Leave type	Entitlement per year	Advance notice	Carry-over
Annual / earned leave	24 working days	14 calendar days for 3+ day blocks	Up to 8 days, expires 31 March
Sick leave	12 working days	Inform manager same day; certificate if 3+ days	Not allowed
Casual leave	6 working days	2 working days	Not allowed
Maternity leave	26 weeks	As per Maternity Benefit Act; max 8 weeks prenatal	Not applicable
Paternity leave	4 weeks	7 calendar days	Not applicable; within 6 months of birth
Bereavement leave	5 working days	Retroactive application within 7 working days	Not applicable

Leave entitlements are pro-rated in the joining year and in the year of exit.

Carry-over: up to 8 days of unused annual leave may be carried into the next leave year; carried-over leave expires on 31 March of that year. Sick leave and casual leave cannot be carried over under any circumstances.

Annual leave of 3 or more consecutive working days requires 14 calendar days of advance notice and manager approval recorded in the HR portal. Leave taken without approval is treated as loss of pay.

Sick leave of more than 3 consecutive working days must be supported by a registered medical practitioner's certificate submitted within 5 working days of rejoining.

Maternity leave of 26 weeks applies as per the Maternity Benefit Act, of which not more than 8 weeks may precede the expected delivery date. Paternity leave of 4 weeks must be availed within 6 months of the child's birth, in blocks of no less than 1 week.

Bereavement leave of 5 working days applies to the loss of an immediate family member (spouse, child, parent, sibling, or grandparent) and must be applied retroactively within 7 working days.

5. Remote and Hybrid Work

Employees whose registered work location is within 50 km of an Acme Corp office must work from that office at least two (2) days per calendar week, unless an exception is approved in writing by the department Director.

Fully remote status (fewer than one office day per month) requires approval of the department Director and the Chief People Officer, is reviewed every six (6) months, and may be revoked with 30 days notice.

A remote work internet allowance is paid to approved fully-remote employees: 1,000 INR per month for Grades L1 to L3. See also Addendum A (2026) for the revised allowance effective 1 March 2026.

Employees working remotely from a location other than their registered address for more than 30 consecutive days must inform HR in writing, as tax and statutory obligations may change.

All remote employees must comply with the Acme Corp IT Security Policy, including mandatory disk encryption and VPN usage for all company systems.

6. Code of Conduct

Employees must disclose any outside employment, directorship, or financial interest greater than 5 percent in a vendor, customer, or competitor of Acme Corp within 10 working days of it arising, using the Conflict of Interest form on the HR portal.

Gifts or hospitality from business partners with a value above 2,500 INR must be declined or declared to Compliance within 5 working days. Cash or cash-equivalent gifts are prohibited in all cases.

Side employment (secondary occupation) requires prior written approval from the reporting manager and the HRBP; approval is denied wherever the secondary occupation competes with Acme Corp or exceeds 20 hours per week.

Public statements about Acme Corp, including on social media, must follow the Communications Policy; employees must not disclose Confidential or Restricted information as defined in the IT Security Policy.

Violations of the Code of Conduct are handled under the disciplinary matrix in Section 12; gross misconduct may result in termination without notice.

7. Anti-Harassment and Grievance Redressal

Acme Corp maintains a zero-tolerance position on workplace harassment, including sexual harassment, which is administered by the Internal Committee (IC) constituted under the POSH Act.

Complaints may be raised with any of the following, in any order: the immediate manager, the HR Business Partner, any member of the Internal Committee, or the anonymous ethics hotline (ethics.acme.example). Complaints are acknowledged within 2 working days.

The grievance resolution timeline is as follows, with escalation automatic when a stage exceeds its limit:

Escalation level	Authority	Response limit
Level 1	Immediate manager	3 business days
Level 2	HR Business Partner	5 business days
Level 3	Chief People Officer	10 business days
POSH complaints	Internal Committee	Acknowledgement 2 days; inquiry within 90 days

POS complaints are inquiry-completed within 90 days as required by law, and the IC's recommendations are implemented within 60 days of the report.

Retaliation against any complainant or witness is itself gross misconduct and is investigated by the Chief People Officer directly.

8. Expense and Travel Policy

All business expenses must be genuine, business-related, supported by original invoices, and submitted through the expense portal within 30 calendar days of the expense date. Late submissions beyond 60 days are reimbursed only with CFO approval.

Travel class and hotel ceilings by grade are as follows (per night, within India):

Grade	Flight class	Hotel ceiling (per night, India)	Local travel
L1	Economy	4,000 INR	Cab, actuals
L2	Premium economy	7,000 INR	Cab, actuals
L3	Business	12,000 INR	Chauffeur for client meetings
L4 (Director+)	Business	18,000 INR	Chauffeur

The meal allowance on business travel within India is 600 INR per day (no receipts required). Incidental expenses are covered at 100 INR per day.

Any single expense above 25,000 INR requires pre-approval from the Chief Financial Officer in addition to the normal manager approval.

International travel requires approval from the department Director, booking through the approved travel desk, and a per-diem as per the international annexure published on the finance portal.

Advances must be settled within 15 days of trip completion; unspent advances are recovered from the next payroll cycle.

9. Performance Management

The performance year runs from 1 April to 31 March. Every employee has documented quarterly check-ins with their manager in the performance portal, and a formal annual review in April.

Ratings are: Exceptional, Exceeds Expectations, Meets Expectations, Needs Improvement, and Unsatisfactory. A rating of Needs Improvement places the employee on a Performance Improvement Plan (PIP) of up to 60 days with fortnightly reviews.

Promotions are effective in the April and October cycles. Eligibility requires a rating of Meets Expectations or higher in the most recent cycle, completion of 12 months in the current grade, and a current-year promotion budget confirmation from Finance.

Two consecutive Unsatisfactory ratings, or failure to exit a PIP successfully, may lead to separation under Section 11.

10. Benefits Summary

All regular employees are covered by group health insurance with a family floater sum insured of 500,000 INR. Employees at Grade L3 and above receive a top-up cover of 200,000 INR. New joiners are enrolled automatically on their start date.

An annual preventive health check-up is covered for employees aged 40 and above, and for all employees at Grade L3 and above, up to 6,000 INR per year.

The learning and development budget is 30,000 INR per year for Grades L2 and above, usable for courses, certifications, and books with manager approval; it does not carry over.

Group term life insurance of 24 months of fixed pay and personal accident cover of 12 months of fixed pay apply to all regular employees at no cost.

Statutory benefits (provident fund, gratuity, and insurance under the ESI Act where applicable) are administered per law and summarized on each payslip.

11. Separation and Exit

Resignation must be submitted through the HR portal. The notice period is 30 calendar days for Grades L1 and L2, and 60 calendar days for Grades L3 and above. Notice pay in lieu is permitted only with mutual written agreement.

During the notice period the employee is expected to complete a structured handover documented in the handover template; the relieving letter is issued only after the reporting manager signs off the handover.

Full and final settlement, including reimbursements and leave encashment (annual leave only, capped at 45 days), is processed within 45 calendar days of the last working day.

All company assets (laptop, access cards, and peripherals) must be returned on or before the last working day; unreturned assets are recovered at book value from the settlement amount.

Termination for cause follows the disciplinary matrix in Section 12 and, where applicable, the procedures of the Internal Committee under the POSH Act.

12. Disciplinary Matrix

Disciplinary action is applied in proportion to severity, with the following standard ladder:

Level	Action	Decision authority
Stage 1	Documented verbal warning	Reporting manager
Stage 2	Written warning	Reporting manager + HRBP
Stage 3	Final written warning or suspension up to 10 days	HRBP + Chief People Officer
Stage 4	Termination	Chief People Officer

The reporting manager may issue a documented verbal warning; every later stage requires HRBP review and, from suspension onward, approval of the Chief People Officer.

An employee may appeal any disciplinary action to the Chief People Officer within 10 working days of being informed; the appeal decision is final.

13. Data Handling Cross-Reference

All employee and customer personal data referenced in this Handbook is classified and handled according to the Acme Corp IT Security Policy 2026, including the data classification scheme (Public, Internal, Confidential, Restricted) defined there.

HR records are Confidential; identity documents, salary information, and health records are Restricted and may be accessed only by named HR roles listed in the HR data register.

Suspected data breaches involving HR records must be reported to security@acme.example within 24 hours under the incident response procedure of the IT Security Policy.